

# Emotional Recovery After a Scam

Being scammed can be devastating. Experiencing a scam can be extremely disappointing, whether you lost money, personal information, or both. Along with the financial stress of a scam, many victims also experience embarrassment and sadness. However, it is important to remember that scams can happen to anyone. Being scammed does not mean you are unintelligent or gullible.

## **Forgive Yourself But Do Not Forget**

As shown by the principles of social engineering, scammers are very skilled at emotionally manipulating others to give in. Therefore, it is important to not criticize yourself for falling for a scam. You might think that you could have objected more, but the scammer would have still tugged you into their trap. Every time you call yourself gullible, reconsider the situation by thinking of your strengths. Clinical psychologist Dr. Katelyn Campbell says that a sense of betrayal is a key factor causing a sense of devastation after a scam, stating “People feel ashamed after being scammed because their trust was violated. They can blame themselves for ‘not knowing better.’” While this is a common experience for victims of scams, it is important to restrain from blaming yourself. Continuing to tear yourself apart will not change the outcome of the scam, so it is important to recognize the scam with self-respect and patience.

Moreover, you should always forgive yourself for falling for the scam, but you should not forget the scam itself. Take note of how the scam occurred, and document as much information as possible. Following the post-scam protocols is extremely important. You should use this experience as a reminder to avoid taking unknown phone calls and always follow the principles of STOP-VERIFY-ASK before making any major financial decisions. This can help you avoid any similar situations like this in the future.

## **Supporting Others**

If you know someone who has been scammed, instead of criticizing them, comfort them. These individuals can sometimes feel intense anxiety, anger, grief, and embarrassment. Tell them that there is always a solution and that they can recover from their situation. They need positive reinforcement in order to recover from the mental grief of experiencing a scam. It is also important to be aware of ways to recover from scams so that you can assist your loved one in this situation.

Moreover, encouraging a scam victim to follow mindfulness practices can also comfort them during this stressful time. Encouraging them to take deep breaths and listen to calm music can help relieve them of their anxiety. However, if you feel that the scam victim could benefit from additional support, you might want to encourage them to talk with a licensed mental health professional if they are struggling to cope emotionally.

Ultimately, being scammed is a terrible experience. However, by talking with people you trust and comforting rather than criticizing yourself, you can learn from the scam and move forward from the experience.

## References

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